

THE FRESH GRADUATE SERIES

The Complete Fresh Graduate Career Bundle

From graduation to your first job - and your first 90 days
Resume, interviews, networking, negotiation and workplace success



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2026 Edition

The Complete Fresh Graduate Career Bundle

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First edition, 2026.

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Before You Begin

Graduation is a strange moment. One week you are chasing deadlines and exams. The next, everyone expects you to simply "start your career" as if there were a clear map. There isn't one, and that is exactly why this book exists.

This bundle walks you through the whole journey in the order you will actually live it: understanding what employers want, building proof of your skills, creating your resume and online profile, finding and applying for roles, interviewing, negotiating your offer, and thriving through your first 90 days on the job.

Who this book is for

- Final-year students and recent graduates applying for their first full-time role
- Graduates switching direction because their degree and their interests don't line up neatly
- Anyone who has sent many applications and heard nothing back

How to use this book

- **Read it in order the first time.** Each chapter builds on the previous one.
- **Do the exercises.** Reading about a resume does not produce a resume. Each chapter ends with an action step; treat it as homework.
- **Use the Toolkit.** The final section has copy-and-adapt templates, a job tracker and a 30-day plan.
- **Adapt to your context.** Advice here is broadly global. Local norms differ, for example whether a photo or personal details appear on a resume, so check what is standard in your country and field.

The big idea

Early in your career, employers are not hiring your past. They are betting on your **potential**. Every chapter in this book is about one thing: giving an employer clear, believable evidence that you learn fast, work reliably and will add value.

The Landscape: What Employers Really Want

Understand the market before you step into it

Most fresh graduates start by writing a resume. The smarter move is to start by understanding what the person reading it is looking for. Employers generally hire graduates for a blend of three things.

Category	What it means	Examples
Transferable skills	Abilities that work in almost any role	Communication, problem-solving, teamwork, time management
Technical skills	Tools and methods specific to a field	Excel, SQL, Python, CRM software, CAD, lab methods, dashboards
Work habits	How you behave day to day	Reliability, attention to detail, speed of learning, ownership

Skills that keep showing up in employer surveys

Several career-skills reports, including a large global employer survey by QS covering more than 26,000 employers, point to the same cluster of abilities for new graduates. In practice they come down to:

- **Analytical and critical thinking.** Looking at information, spotting what matters and drawing a sensible conclusion. It sits near the top of virtually every major employer skills survey.
- **Data and AI literacy.** Reading a dashboard, using basic analysis tools, and judging whether an AI-generated answer is trustworthy. Graduates who also use AI tools to work faster tend to stand out.
- **Communication.** Writing a clear email, explaining your thinking, and listening well, including in remote or cross-cultural teams.
- **Initiative and ownership.** Noticing what needs doing and doing it without being asked.
- **Adaptability.** Learning new tools and shifting priorities without panic.

Reality check

Employers rarely expect a graduate to be an expert. They want evidence that you can learn quickly and be trusted with real work. A modest internship result, a solid project or a student-club responsibility often counts for more than a long list of generic claims.

Where graduates typically start

Entry routes vary by field, but common first roles include sales or business development, operations and project coordination, content and social media, customer success and support, junior analyst roles in finance or data, and graduate trainee programmes. Some of these are generalist starts. That is often an advantage: you learn how a business works before you specialise.

Salary or growth: which matters more for job number one?

Career advisers commonly suggest that, early on, learning is worth more than a slightly higher starting figure. A role that teaches you in-demand technical and interpersonal skills usually pays back far more over the next decade than a small salary bump in a role where you stop growing. That does not mean accepting unfair pay. It means weighing the whole package, including mentorship, learning and the brand of the employer.

Action step

- [] Write down three industries or role types that interest you (you can change them later).
- [] Open five real job postings for each and highlight the skills that repeat.
- [] Make a list of the top 8 repeated skills. This is your skill-gap map for Chapter 3.

CHAPTER 2

Know Yourself, Choose Direction

A simple self-audit before you apply anywhere

You do not need a perfect five-year plan. You do need enough direction to write a targeted resume, because a resume aimed at "any job" usually convinces no one. The goal of this chapter is a one-sentence **career target** you can test in the real world.

The four-circle self-audit

Draw four circles and fill them in honestly. Where they overlap, you will find roles worth exploring.

Circle	Questions to ask yourself
What I'm good at	What do classmates ask me for help with? Which assignments felt easy?
What I enjoy	Which tasks make time disappear? What would I do unpaid for a weekend?
What the market pays for	Which roles are hiring in volume? What skills do postings repeat?
What I can live with	Hours, location, travel, pace, stress level, salary floor

Turning your degree into skills

Employers do not hire a degree title. They hire what you can do. Take your last three big assignments, projects or activities and translate each:

What you did	Skill it proves
Wrote a 40-page dissertation	Research, structuring arguments, deadlines, independent work
Led a college club or event	Leadership, budgeting, coordination, persuasion
Group project with conflict	Teamwork, negotiation, accountability
Part-time job or tutoring	Reliability, customer handling, explaining complex ideas

Write your career target

Use this formula and keep it specific enough to fit in a LinkedIn headline:

Career target formula

I am a [degree] graduate aiming for [role type] roles in [industry or function], with strengths in [skill 1], [skill 2] and [skill 3].

Example: "English graduate aiming for content and communications roles in education technology, with strengths in writing, editing and client communication."

It's fine to pivot

Your first job rarely defines your whole career. Treat your target as a hypothesis. Apply, learn what you like and dislike, and adjust. A generalist start is perfectly respectable.

Action step

- [] Complete the four-circle audit on one page.
- [] Translate three experiences into skills using the table above.
- [] Write your career target sentence and keep it visible while you work through this book.

Build Proof Before You Have a Job

How to close skill gaps and create evidence employers can see

"No experience" is the most common worry among graduates and it is usually solvable. Employers accept many things as proof: internships, projects, volunteering, certifications, freelance work and published work. What matters is that the proof is **specific and visible**.

Five ways to create proof quickly

1. **Take a targeted course or certification.** Platforms such as Coursera, Udemy and Google Career Certificates are widely used to offset a lack of experience. Choose courses tied to skills that appear repeatedly in your target job postings, and finish them.
2. **Build a small project.** A dashboard, a short research report, a content series, a simple website or an automated spreadsheet. Pick a real problem and document what you did and what you learned.
3. **Volunteer or help a small organisation.** Local non-profits, student bodies and small businesses often welcome help with social media, data entry, events or research.
4. **Do an internship or short freelance gig.** Even a few weeks gives you concrete bullet points and a reference.
5. **Learn in public.** Share what you are learning on LinkedIn or a blog. It shows initiative and gives recruiters something to find.

Make your projects hire-worthy

A project becomes proof when someone can understand it in thirty seconds. For every project, write down:

- **The problem:** what you set out to solve
- **Your approach:** tools, methods and decisions
- **The result:** a number, a finished product or a clear takeaway
- **A link:** portfolio page, GitHub, Tableau Public, Google Drive folder or a short write-up

Build a portfolio, even if you are not a designer

A portfolio is simply a tidy place where your best work lives. Writers can use a blog or Google Drive folder. Analysts can publish dashboards. Marketers can show campaigns or mock plans. Aim for three to five strong items rather than twenty weak ones. Put the link on your resume and your LinkedIn profile.

Learn the AI tools of your field

Employers increasingly value graduates who can use AI tools to work faster and who can check the output critically. Practise using AI for drafts, research and data tasks, and always verify the results yourself. Being able to say how you used it responsibly is a real advantage.

Action step

- [] Pick your top two skill gaps from Chapter 1.
- [] Choose one course or resource per gap and schedule it in your calendar.
- [] Start one portfolio project this week, however small.

The Resume That Gets Interviews

A practical guide to a one-page graduate resume

Your resume has one job: win you a conversation. It is read quickly, often first by software (an Applicant Tracking System, or ATS) and then by a person who may spend only seconds on it. Design it to be scannable and relevant.

The ground rules

- **Keep it to one page.** Entry-level candidates rarely need more.
- **Use a simple layout.** Avoid tables, columns, text boxes and images, which can confuse ATS software. Use standard headings such as Education, Experience, Projects and Skills.
- **Use keywords from the job description** naturally. If a posting says "stakeholder communication", and you have done it, use that phrase rather than a different one.
- **Show results, not duties.** "Responsible for" tells the reader nothing. A result does.
- **Tailor it for each role.** Re-order your bullets and adjust keywords for every application.
- **Save and send as PDF** unless the application asks for another format.

Recommended structure for a graduate

Most advisers recommend a **combination format**, mixing skills and experience, for people with limited work history.

Section	What goes in it
Header	Name, phone, professional email, city, LinkedIn and portfolio links
Professional summary	2-3 lines: your degree, your target role and your top skills
Education	Degree, university, graduation year, relevant coursework, honours. GPA only if it helps (many advisers say include it if strong or if requested)
Experience	Internships, part-time jobs, volunteering, leadership roles with 2-4 bullets each
Projects	1-3 strongest projects with what you did and the result
Skills	Technical tools and relevant soft skills backed by examples elsewhere on the page
Certifications	Courses and certificates that match the role

The bullet formula

Action verb + what you did + how + result

Weak: Responsible for helping organise college events.

Strong: Organised a three-day campus workshop for 120 attendees, coordinating 8 volunteers and finishing 10% under budget.

If you don't have exact numbers, use honest approximations such as team size, number of people served, frequency or time saved. Never invent figures. Interviewers will ask about them.

Before-and-after examples

Before (weak)	After (strong)
Worked on social media for the club	Planned and posted 4 weekly pieces of content for the club's Instagram, growing followers steadily over one semester
Did data entry at a part-time job	Entered and verified 200+ records daily with a high accuracy rate, flagging errors to the team lead
Good communication skills	Presented project findings to a panel of 15 faculty and peers, earning the top grade in the cohort

Strong action verbs

Analysed, built, coordinated, created, delivered, designed, developed, drafted, improved, led, launched, managed, organised, presented, reduced, researched, streamlined, supported, tested, trained.

Common mistakes

- Long paragraphs instead of short bullets
- A generic objective such as "seeking a challenging role"
- Typos and inconsistent formatting. Ask someone else to proofread.
- Unprofessional email addresses
- Leaving off "unrelated" jobs. A part-time job shows reliability and work ethic.
- Keeping school-level information once you have university or work content

Resume checklist

- ☐ One page, simple layout, saved as PDF
- ☐ Keywords from the target job description included
- ☐ Every bullet starts with an action verb and shows a result where possible
- ☐ Links to LinkedIn and portfolio work
- ☐ Proofread by at least one other person

CHAPTER 5

Cover Letters That Get Read

A short, personal note that makes your resume come alive

Not every employer asks for a cover letter, but a good one can separate you from candidates with similar resumes. Think of it as a short, human argument for why **you** suit **this** role at **this** company.

The past, present, future method

Paragraph	Purpose	What to write
Opening	Hook	Why this role and company, in one specific sentence
Past	Proof	One accomplishment that shows a skill the role needs
Present	Fit	What you are building or learning now and how it connects to the job
Future	Value	What you hope to contribute and a polite call to action

Template

Dear [Hiring Manager's name],

I'm writing to apply for the [Role] position at [Company]. I was drawn to [specific thing: a project, product, value or recent news] because [one genuine reason].

During my [degree/internship/project], I [specific achievement with a result], which taught me [skill relevant to the role].

Right now I'm [course, project or experience] to strengthen my [skill], which I believe would help me contribute to [team goal].

I would welcome the chance to discuss how I can support [Company]. Thank you for your time and consideration.

*Sincerely,
[Your name]*

Rules of thumb

- Address a named person where possible.
- Keep it under one page, around 250 to 350 words.
- Don't repeat your resume. Add the story behind it.
- Never send the same letter to every company. Specificity is what makes it work.
- Read it aloud. If it sounds stiff, simplify.

CHAPTER 6

LinkedIn and Your Online Presence

Recruiters will look you up. Make sure they like what they find.

For many roles, your online profile is part of your application. Recruiters search by keywords and job titles, and hiring managers often check profiles before inviting candidates to interview.

Profile essentials

Element	What good looks like
Photo	Clear, well lit, friendly, professional. Not a selfie or a cropped group photo.
Headline	Says more than "Recent Graduate". Example: "Entry-Level Data Analyst Excel, SQL, Power BI" or "Graduate Trainee, Finance Reporting and Financial Modelling".
About	First-person, short story: who you are, what you're good at, what you're looking for.
Experience	Every internship, project and role with concrete details and results.
Skills	Role-relevant skills; ask people who have worked with you to endorse them.
Featured	Link to your best project, portfolio, article or presentation.

A simple About section formula

Template

I'm a [degree] graduate from [university] who enjoys [type of work]. I've [one or two concrete experiences or projects with results]. I'm now looking for [role type] opportunities where I can [what you want to do and learn]. Outside work, I [one human detail]. Feel free to message me at [email].

Clean up the rest of your footprint

- Search your own name and see what appears.
- Tighten privacy settings on personal social media or keep content professional.
- Use a consistent name, photo and bio across professional platforms.
- Post occasionally: a project update, something you learned, or a thoughtful comment on industry news.

Networking Without the Awkwardness

Most jobs begin with a conversation, not an application

Networking sounds like schmoozing at events, but for a graduate it is simpler and kinder: **asking people about their work and learning from them**. Many roles are filled through referrals and relationships, and a short conversation can put your resume in front of the right person.

Who to talk to

- Alumni from your university who work in your target field
- Seniors, teachers and supervisors from internships
- Friends and family members, and their contacts
- People who post about topics you care about on LinkedIn
- Speakers and attendees at webinars and campus events

The golden rule: ask for advice, not a job

People are far more willing to give fifteen minutes of advice than to hand over a job lead. A good conversation often leads to the second naturally.

First message template (LinkedIn or email)

Hi [Name], I'm a recent [degree] graduate exploring [field] roles. I came across your profile and found your work on [specific thing] really interesting. Would you be open to a quick 15-minute chat about how you got started in [field]? I'd really value any advice. Thank you for considering it!

Questions to ask in an informal chat

- How did you get into this field, and what surprised you most about it?
- What does a typical week look like in your role?
- What skills matter most for someone starting out?
- If you were in my position, what would you do in the next three months?
- Is there anyone else you think I should speak to?

After the conversation

- Send a thank-you message within 24 hours, mentioning something specific they said.
- Act on their advice and tell them what happened. People love hearing the outcome.
- Keep a simple list of contacts, dates and follow-ups.

Action step

- [] Make a list of 10 people you could contact.
- [] Send 3 messages this week using the template.
- [] Aim for at least two conversations in the next 30 days.

CHAPTER 8

A Smart Job Search Strategy

Apply with focus, track everything and use your time wisely

Sending hundreds of identical applications rarely works. A focused routine does.

Where to look

- Company career pages for organisations you admire
- Large job boards and professional networks such as LinkedIn and Indeed, plus strong regional portals in your country (for example, Naukri in India)
- University placement cells and alumni networks
- Graduate trainee and management trainee programmes
- Referrals from your network
- Startups and small businesses, which often hire quickly and give broad responsibility

Weekly routine that works

Activity	Suggested weekly effort
Tailored applications (quality over quantity)	5 to 10
Networking messages or conversations	3 to 5
Skill-building or project work	3 to 5 hours
Interview practice	2 sessions
Review and adjust what's working	30 minutes

Use AI tools wisely

AI tools can help you draft cover-letter outlines, summarise job descriptions, brainstorm interview questions and practise answers. Use them as a coach, not a ghostwriter. Always edit the output so it sounds like you and is accurate.

Track your applications

A simple spreadsheet prevents missed follow-ups. A ready-made tracker is in the Toolkit at the end of this book.

Handling rejection and silence

Silence and rejection are normal and rarely personal. Review your results after 15 to 20 applications. If you get no interviews, the problem is likely your resume or targeting. If you get interviews but no offers, work on your interview preparation.

CHAPTER 9

Acing the Interview

Prepare once, perform confidently every time

Interviews are a skill, which means they can be practised. The candidates who seem naturally confident are usually just well prepared.

Prepare these five things before every interview

1. **Research the company.** What they do, who their customers are, recent news and the role itself.
2. **A 90-second "Tell me about yourself".** Present, past, future: what you do now, what led you here, and why you're excited about this role.
3. **Three strong stories.** Examples from school, internships or work that show problem-solving, teamwork and results.
4. **Two or three smart questions** about the team, the work or the company's direction.
5. **Logistics.** Test your tech, plan your route or log in early, and have a copy of your resume ready.

The STAR method for behavioural questions

Questions such as "Tell me about a time you faced a challenge" are best answered with a simple structure:

Letter	Meaning	Guidance
S	Situation	Set the scene briefly (one or two sentences)
T	Task	What was your responsibility or goal?
A	Action	What did you do? Spend most of your time here
R	Result	What happened? Add numbers or a lesson learned

Example answer outline

Question: Tell me about a time you worked under pressure.

S: In my final semester, three assignments and a group presentation fell in the same week.

T: I was responsible for the research and slides for the presentation.

A: I broke the work into daily goals, asked teammates to review in parallel and prepared early so there was time to rehearse.

R: We delivered on time, received strong feedback, and I now use the same planning method at work.

Common questions to practise

- Tell me about yourself.

- Why do you want this role and this company?
- What are your strengths and your areas for improvement?
- Describe a time you worked in a team and faced disagreement.
- Tell me about a mistake you made and what you learned.
- Where do you see yourself in a few years?
- Do you have any questions for us?

Good questions to ask the interviewer

- What does success look like in this role in the first three months?
- What are the biggest priorities for the team right now?
- How is feedback given to new team members?
- What do you enjoy most about working here?
- What are the next steps in the process?

After the interview

Thank-you email template

Subject: Thank you - [Role] interview

Dear [Name],

Thank you for taking the time to speak with me today about the [Role] position. I enjoyed learning about [specific topic discussed] and I'm even more excited about the opportunity to contribute to [team or goal]. Please let me know if I can provide anything further.

Kind regards,

[Your name]

Video interviews

Use a quiet space, a plain background, good lighting and a camera at eye level. Look at the camera when you speak and keep notes just out of frame.

Offers and Salary Negotiation

Handle money conversations calmly and professionally

Many graduates avoid negotiating because they fear the offer will be withdrawn. In practice, polite, well-researched negotiation is normal, and many employers expect it. The key words are **polite** and **well-researched**.

Step 1: Research your market value

- Look up typical entry-level pay for your role, city and industry using salary sites, job postings that list ranges, alumni and your university's placement data.
- Treat averages with care. Self-reported salary data can skew high.
- Decide three numbers: your ideal, your realistic target and your walk-away minimum.

Step 2: Handle the early salary question

If asked about expectations early in the process, you can politely turn the question around or give a range based on research. Avoid naming a random number.

If you'd like to deflect

"I'd like to learn more about the responsibilities first. Could you share the salary range budgeted for this role?"

If you must give a figure

"Based on my research for entry-level [role] positions in [city], I'm looking at [range]. I'm flexible depending on the full package and growth opportunities."

Step 3: Wait for the offer, then ask

The best moment to negotiate is after you receive an offer, because they have already decided they want you. Thank them warmly first, then ask.

Negotiation script

"Thank you so much for the offer. I'm really excited about joining [Company]. Based on my research of entry-level [role] salaries in [city] and my background in [relevant experience or skill], I was hoping for something closer to [target]. Is there flexibility on the salary?"

If the base salary can't move

"I understand the base is fixed. Would it be possible to review my compensation after six months of strong performance, or to add [learning budget / flexible working / joining bonus]?"

Look beyond the base number

Component	Why it matters
Base salary	The foundation for future raises
Bonus or incentives	Check how they are calculated and when they are paid
Learning and training	Courses, certifications and mentorship
Flexibility	Remote or hybrid options, working hours
Benefits	Health cover, leave, retirement contributions
Notice period and probation	Terms that affect how easily you can move later
Review cycle	When your performance and pay are reviewed

Do's and don'ts

- **Do** stay warm and enthusiastic throughout.
- **Do** ask for the offer in writing and read it fully.
- **Do** take a day or two to consider before replying.
- **Don't** bluff about competing offers.
- **Don't** accept or reject on the spot if you are unsure.
- **Don't** negotiate only by email if a phone call is possible. Tone carries better in conversation.

Note

Employment law and norms vary widely by country. For anything involving contracts, bonds, non-compete terms or notice periods, read the document carefully and seek qualified advice if unsure.

Your First 90 Days

How to turn a good start into a strong reputation

Many employers see the first three months as an extension of the interview. You were hired for your potential; now you show it. The good news: the first 90 days are mostly about **learning**, not proving you know everything.

The three-stage plan

Stage	Focus	What to do
Days 1-30	Learn and observe	Meet your team, learn tools and terminology, ask questions, keep a running notebook of processes and unwritten rules. Note ideas for improvement, but hold off on changing things until you understand why they exist.
Days 31-60	Contribute	Take full ownership of a few tasks from start to finish. Solve routine problems on your own before asking for help. Ask for feedback.
Days 61-90	Show impact	Share a concrete improvement idea. Review your progress with your manager and agree on next goals and a learning plan.

Habits that build credibility fast

- **Be a learner, not a knower.** Humility and curiosity are attractive in a new hire.
- **Keep a "brag book".** Record your achievements, positive feedback and learning as you go.
- **Clarify expectations early.** Ask your manager, "What does success look like in three months?"
- **Be reliably on time, prepared and responsive.**
- **Take notes and don't ask the same question twice.**
- **Build relationships beyond your team.** Isolation slows your growth.
- **Invite feedback and take it well.** Listen, say thanks, and apply it.

Good questions for week one

- What are the team's main priorities this quarter?
- How do you prefer to communicate: chat, email or meetings?
- What is something you wish new joiners understood sooner?
- Who should I get to know in other teams?

What if something feels wrong?

Starting a job is tiring, and discomfort is normal. Experienced advisers suggest giving yourself time to tell apart "*this is hard because it's new*" from "*this is genuinely wrong*". Quitting in the first few

months is usually unwise unless the situation crosses a clear ethical or legal line. Talk to a mentor or trusted friend outside the workplace before deciding.

Action step

- [] Draft your own 30-60-90 day plan (template in the Toolkit).
- [] Schedule a short check-in with your manager in week two.
- [] Start your brag book on day one.

Workplace Skills That Make You Stand Out

Communication, time management and professionalism

Writing clear emails and messages

- Use a specific subject line: "Question on Q3 report format", not "Hi".
- Put the main point or request in the first two lines.
- Keep paragraphs short and use bullet points for lists.
- End with a clear next step and a deadline if relevant.
- Reread before sending. Check names, attachments and tone.

Asking for help well

"Hi [Name], I'm working on [task]. I've tried [what you tried] and I'm stuck on [specific problem]. Could you point me to the right resource or spare five minutes this afternoon?"

Managing your time

- Write your top three priorities each morning.
- Batch similar tasks together, such as replying to messages at set times.
- Estimate how long tasks will take and add a buffer.
- If you're running late on a task, tell your manager early with a plan, not on the deadline day.
- Protect time for focused work by silencing notifications for short blocks.

Receiving feedback

1. Listen fully without interrupting or defending.
2. Ask clarifying questions: "Can you give me an example of what you'd like to see?"
3. Thank the person. Feedback is a gift even when it stings.
4. Write down the action points and follow up on progress.

Working across time zones and cultures

Many modern teams are remote or spread across locations. Confirm time zones in writing, summarise decisions after meetings, avoid slang that may not translate and be generous in assuming good intent. Clear written communication matters even more in distributed teams.

Professional presence

- Be punctual, including for virtual meetings.

- Keep commitments or renegotiate them early.
- Be respectful to everyone, regardless of seniority.
- Keep confidential matters confidential.
- Take ownership when you make a mistake: say what happened, how you'll fix it and how you'll prevent it.

Money Basics for Your First Paycheque

Simple habits that protect you as your income begins

Your first salary is exciting. A few early habits can make a big difference later. This chapter is general education only, not personal financial advice.

Start with a simple budget

List your fixed costs (rent, transport, phone, loan repayments) and variable costs (food, entertainment, shopping). Many people find a simple split of needs, wants and savings easy to follow. Choose proportions that suit your costs, and adjust as your income changes.

Build a safety cushion

An emergency fund, money set aside for unexpected costs or a gap between jobs, gives you freedom to make career decisions without panic. Start small and add to it every month, even if the amount feels modest.

Avoid lifestyle inflation

It's tempting to raise spending as soon as income rises. If you can, keep your lifestyle close to what it was for a while and direct part of every raise to savings or investments.

Understand your payslip and benefits

- Learn the difference between gross pay and take-home pay.
- Understand deductions such as tax and retirement contributions.
- Find out what health cover, leave and other benefits you have, and how to use them.

Be careful with credit and debt

- Treat credit cards as a payment tool, not extra income.
- Pay balances in full where possible to avoid interest.
- Be cautious with high-interest loans and "buy now, pay later" offers.
- Learn how credit scores or histories work in your country.

Remember

Rules on tax, investments and savings schemes differ by country. Use official government and bank resources, or speak to a qualified adviser, before making significant decisions.

Resilience, Wellbeing and the Long Game

Your first job is a beginning, not a verdict

The path from graduation to a satisfying career is rarely a straight line. Setbacks do not mean you are failing; they are part of the process almost everyone goes through.

When the search feels heavy

- **Keep routines.** Sleep, movement and time with friends keep you steady.
- **Set small daily goals** rather than judging yourself on outcomes you can't control.
- **Talk to people.** Mentors, friends or peers at the same stage can remind you that this is normal.
- **Celebrate small wins:** a reply, an interview, a new skill learned.
- **Take breaks.** Rest improves performance.

If stress or low mood begins to affect your daily life, please speak to a trusted person or a qualified professional. Looking after your health is part of looking after your career.

Keep growing after you land the job

- Revisit your goals every six months.
- Keep learning something new each quarter.
- Stay in touch with your network, even when you don't need anything.
- Seek a mentor, and later, become one.
- Update your resume and LinkedIn every few months so you are never starting from scratch.

A final thought

Employers are looking for people who are curious, reliable and kind to work with. You already have more of those qualities than you think. Now it's about making them visible.

THE TOOLKIT

The Toolkit

Templates, trackers and plans you can copy and use today

Toolkit 1: 30-day action plan

Week	Focus	Key tasks
Week 1	Foundation	Complete self-audit; write career target; pick 2 skill gaps; begin a course and a project
Week 2	Materials	Draft resume and LinkedIn; get feedback from two people; write a base cover letter
Week 3	Outreach	Send 5 networking messages; submit 5 to 10 tailored applications; set up your tracker
Week 4	Interview ready	Prepare your 90-second intro and 3 STAR stories; do two mock interviews; review and adjust your strategy

Toolkit 2: Job application tracker

Company	Role	Date applied	Link	Status	Next step

Tip: recreate this table in a spreadsheet. Add columns for contact person, follow-up date and notes.

Toolkit 3: 30-60-90 day plan template

	Goals	Actions	How I'll measure it
Day 1-30	Learn the role, tools and people		
Day 31-60	Own a few tasks end to end		
Day 61-90	Show impact and plan ahead		

Toolkit 4: Follow-up message after no reply

After an application (about one week later)

Dear [Name], I recently applied for the [Role] position and wanted to reiterate my interest. I'm particularly excited about [specific reason]. If there is any additional information I can provide, I'd be glad to. Thank you for your time.

Accepting an offer

Dear [Name], thank you very much for the offer. I'm delighted to accept the position of [Role] at [Company], starting on [date]. Please let me know about any documents or next steps before then. I look forward to joining the team.

Politely declining an offer

Dear [Name], thank you for offering me the [Role] position and for the time you invested in me. After careful consideration I have decided to pursue another opportunity. I truly appreciate your support and hope our paths cross again.

Toolkit 5: Master checklist

- [] Career target sentence written
- [] Two skill gaps identified and learning plan started
- [] One portfolio project in progress or published
- [] One-page resume tailored and proofread
- [] LinkedIn profile updated with headline, About and featured work
- [] Ten networking contacts listed; three messages sent
- [] Tracker set up; weekly routine scheduled
- [] 90-second intro and three STAR stories prepared
- [] Salary research done with three numbers decided
- [] 30-60-90 plan drafted before day one

Sources and Further Reading

This book draws on publicly available career advice from the following sources, which are worth reading for more detail. All material has been summarised and rewritten in original words.

- StylingCV: fresher and fresh graduate resume guides (resume structure, combination format, certifications)
- ClearPoint HCo: career launch strategies for new graduates (ATS-friendly resumes, cover letters, networking)
- MyCVCreator: fresh graduate career guide (transferable skills, LinkedIn headlines, one-page CVs)
- InternBoard: skills employers want from fresh graduates (analytical thinking, AI and data literacy; references QS Global Employer Survey, NACE Job Outlook and the World Economic Forum Future of Jobs Report)
- SystemOne: guide to landing your first job (LinkedIn profile tips, interview preparation)
- Indeed Career Advice: resume writing, entry-level salary negotiation and salary-expectation answers
- Robert Half: salary negotiation tips for recent graduates
- Prosple: guide to negotiating salary as a fresh grad
- Revarta and Extern: first-job salary negotiation scripts and guidance
- ABR Jobs, University of Denver Career Center, UC Berkeley Executive Education, TopResume and College Recruiter: first 90 days at a new job
- Indiviti: succeeding in the first 90 days (growth conversations and wellbeing)
- Lulu, Amazon KDP and FormatMyEbook: eBook front matter and back matter structure used for this book

Always verify current figures, tools and practices, because job markets change.

Thank you for reading

If this book helped you, please share it with a friend who is about to graduate and consider leaving an honest review.